EXECUTIVE OFFICE OF THE PRESIDENT
NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL
WASHINGTON

~~TOP SECRET~~

COPY NO. 1

August 2, 1950

MEMORANDUM FOR THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL

SUBJECT: Defense of Formosa

REFERENCE: Memo for NSC from Executive Secretary, same subject, dated July 31, 1950

With respect to the recommendations contained in the enclosure to the reference memorandum on the subject, referred by the President to the National Security Council and the Secretary of the Treasury for consideration as a matter of urgency, the following replies have been received to date:

State: The Secretary of State disapproves, with comments as contained in the enclosure.

NSRB: The Chairman, NSRB, approves.

In view of the above replies and of the urgency of this matter, it is being scheduled for consideration as an item on the agenda of the next regularly scheduled Council meeting on Thursday, August 3, 1950.

James S. Lay, Jr.
JAMES S. LAY, Jr.
Executive Secretary

cc: The Secretary of the Treasury

NSC ltr. [illegible] 11-5-91 [illegible]
NC 12-17-91

~~TOP SECRET~~

COPY

~~TOP SECRET~~

DEPARTMENT OF STATE
Office of the Secretary
WASHINGTON

Comments on the Recommendations of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

on

DEFENSE OF FORMOSA

The decision to use the Seventh Fleet to neutralize Formosa militarily in the present crisis was based upon the considerations set forth by the President in his statement of June 27 and in his message to Congress of July 19. We have presented these considerations to a number of other governments in an effort to obtain a measure of international support for a step which had no United Nations sanction and which involves issues on which the governments of the free world have sharply divergent views.

If the Department of Defense and the Joint Chiefs of Staff now consider that their presently available resources are inadequate to carry out their directive concerning Formosa, that conclusion is of the gravest importance and should be brought to the President's attention immediately.

With regard to mining operations, it would seem to be clearly within existing policy for the Chinese to mine areas essential to the defense of Nationalist-held islands off the coast of China and for United States and Chinese forces to mine areas off Formosa or the Pescadores. The usual precautions such as notification to international shipping would have to be considered.

The launching of preventive bombing attacks by either U. S. or Chinese Nationalist forces against the mainland or against concentrations in mainland territorial waters, however, would have most serious results and would be unacceptable from a foreign policy point of view. Some of the more important factors are the following:

a. Whether preventive attacks are made against the Chinese mainland by U. S. forces or by Chinese Nationalist forces acting under the umbrella of U. S. naval protection, the international political responsibility of the United States would be the same.

b. We are not at war with Communist China nor do we wish to become involved in hostilities with Chinese Communist forces. Our commitments may already be

~~TOP SECRET~~

greater than our present capabilities; the action recommended would extend our involvement.

c. We now face a risk of hostilities between Formosa and the mainland; the action recommended would convert the risk into a certainty by our own decision. There is, as yet, no reliable intelligence information that an attack on Formosa is imminent. We understand that reconnaissance thus far has not confirmed reports on unusual concentrations of junks referred to in current intelligence estimates, although it is conceded that reconnaissance has been inadequate as a basis for firm conclusions on this point.

d. The action recommended would place us in a minority of almost one if the matter were brought before the United Nations Security Council and we should be confronted by a major diplomatic problem in our relations with friendly governments.

e. If we or the Chinese Nationalists should now precipitate hostilities between Formosa and the mainland, the probability of Chinese Communist overt intervention with armed forces in Korea or attack on Indochina would be greatly increased. The military advantage of preventive attacks by the Chinese Nationalists against the mainland would have to be weighed, from a United States point of view, against Chinese Communist intervention in Korea or Indochina.

f. Other Members of the United Nations contributing forces for Korea would be under great pressure to withdraw such support if Chinese intervention were afforded a pretext by action taken by us with respect to Formosa.

g. The capabilities of the Chinese Nationalist Air Force to achieve a serious military effect through the proposed action has not been set forth. It would be useful to consider whether we should elect major political and possibly military difficulties in exchange for minor military effect. Presumably if the Chinese Nationalist Air Force had adequate capabilities these would have been revealed at the time of the attack on Hainan or during their operations against the mainland prior to June 27 unless it be true that the Chinese Communists have recently presented much more vulnerable targets.

h. The ability of the free world to resist aggression depends upon moral and psychological as well as upon military factors. If the enemy is clearly and unequivocally branded by our own and world public opinion as the aggressor, the political and military advantages are obvious. Similarly, it seems to me that we should take considerable military risks rather than place ourselves in the role of an aggressor by launching an attack on our own initiative, unless there are overwhelming considerations of national security involved.

In the light of the foregoing, it is recommended that existing United States policies and directives regarding the defense of Formosa be continued. These policies and directives should, however, be kept under constant scrutiny and should be reviewed if reconnaissance of the Chinese coast should clearly reveal the imminence of an attack or if it should be determined that the United States is no longer capable of neutralizing Formosa.

HARRY S. TRUMAN LIBRARY
"NATIONAL ARCHIVES AND RECORDS SERVICE"
U.S. GOVERNMENT